12-06 第2篇

阅读理解（记叙文） The Twenty Minutes I Swept Snow for Old Ms Wang

① On the Sunday morning after the first heavy snow of December, I was the first person in our flat to wake up, at **07:05**, because of the unusually bright light coming through the curtains. The city had turned, overnight, into another world: white roofs, white trees, white cars with small soft mountains on top. When I opened the window a finger-width, the air outside was **thin, sharp, and very clean**. I pulled on a coat over my pyjamas, put on boots, took the small dustpan and the long straw broom from the balcony corner, and went downstairs. My plan was simple: help Dad clear the small square of pavement in front of our building door, as I usually did after every snowfall. I did not expect, at the bottom of the stairs, to meet **Old Ms Wang**.

② Old Ms Wang lives on the first floor, Apartment 102. She is **seventy-nine** this winter, a widow, very thin, with short white hair always pinned up with one green clip. Her daughter lives in Xi'an, more than a thousand kilometres away. Most days, Ms Wang walks slowly to the corner shop at 08:00 for her bread and milk; on Sundays, she also walks a little further, to the park bench near the plum tree, to sit for twenty minutes. This morning, I found her at the foot of our staircase, in a dark blue coat, holding **a very short, very old bamboo broom** — the kind that was made in the 1970s, light brown, tied with red cord. She was trying to sweep the snow in front of the building door, and the broom was almost taller than she was. She had already been sweeping, I guessed, for perhaps ten minutes. A small, careful path — a metre wide, three metres long — stretched back toward the door. The rest of the pavement was still deep, knee-high on the edges where the wind had piled it.

③ "Ms Wang," I said, slowly. She looked up, surprised and slightly embarrassed, like someone caught doing something she was not supposed to. *"Little Yiran! You are up early."* She tried to straighten, and I could see her breath, fast and white, in the cold. *"Ms Wang,"* I said, *"please, let me. My broom is longer."* She paused. Old people, I have learned, often do not like to be helped — it is a small pride worth respecting. But today she looked at my long broom, then at her own short one, and, in a rare small surrender, she said, *"Alright, Yiran. Only for twenty minutes. After that I will make you a bowl of hot sugar-water."* This was her way of saying **thank you without saying it**. I nodded. I began to sweep.

④ Sweeping snow, I discovered, is not like sweeping dust. The broom has to go at a low angle, almost flat, and you push, not drag. You must keep the sweeping line **straight**, not because straight lines are prettier, but because a wavy path refreezes into a dangerous mess by afternoon. I made a straight line of two metres wide down the middle of the

pavement, then cleared the edges outward, as I had watched my father do a hundred times. The snow was light and dry, a good kind of snow for sweeping. My hands got cold inside the gloves, then warmed from the work, then reached that good, honest, hot-cold feeling you get from real outdoor labour. **Work**, I remembered my father saying last year, **has its own small fire in it.**

⑤ After about twelve minutes, I looked up. Ms Wang had gone back up to her apartment. Through her living-room window I could see her small figure, moving carefully around the table, and — after a moment — the window opened and she called softly, *"Yiran, the water will be ready in five minutes!"* I lifted my broom in the universal yes-I-hear-you wave. I kept sweeping. I swept a wider path now to the bicycle shed; I swept the base of the two small cypress trees; I swept the flat stone step in front of the building door clean, down to the grey concrete. Then, as a last small kindness, I pushed the broken bamboo broom and my straw broom side by side under the staircase shelter, so the snow would not soak them overnight.

⑥ When I came into her small apartment at 07:35, the sugar-water was ready — plain hot water with a few drops of ginger juice and a spoon of brown sugar. Ms Wang handed me the bowl and said, *"Yiran, sit."* I sat. The apartment was warm, smelled of old books and a faint orange tangerine peel on the window ledge. On the wall was a framed black-and-white photograph of a younger Ms Wang standing with her husband by what looked like a small lake. *"Nineteen seventy-six,"* she said, following my eyes. *"Kunming. We went in the spring."* She did not explain more, and I did not ask.

⑦ She sat across from me and said something I did not expect. *"When I was thirteen, Yiran, a winter like this, a neighbour boy — Huang Ruyi — swept the snow for me in front of our old courtyard in Qingdao. I had been ill for a week. He was ten, maybe eleven. His broom was too short. My mother, who was a teacher, gave him a small red mandarin. He peeled it in the snow, half for me, half for him. I never forgot."* She paused. *"Today,"* she said, *"you swept my path. In some way, the world has returned a little piece of that morning to me. Thank you, Yiran."* Her eyes were shining but not wet. I was fourteen and could not, at that moment, find words that were not stupid. I just said, slowly, *"It was nothing, Ms Wang. It was only twenty minutes."* She smiled. *"That is exactly what he said."*

⑧ I walked home up the two flights of stairs at 08:05, the empty bowl in my hand, warmed by sugar-water inside and outdoor work outside. I put the bowl on our kitchen counter, changed into dry clothes, and, at breakfast, told my mother about the morning, **but not about the 1976 mandarin**. Some stories do not belong fully to us; they are small warm objects that old people put into our hands, and we learn, as we grow, when to keep them quiet. Mother nodded. *"It was a good Sunday, Yiran."* Yes. It was a good Sunday.

⑨ Later, at the window, I looked down at the pavement I had swept. The cold air would, by noon, freeze it into a clean, grey walking path for the whole building. I thought about

Huang Ruyi in 1957 and his too-short broom, and Ms Wang at thirteen, and her mother the teacher with a small red mandarin. And I realised that **snow**, which seems to cover everything, actually has a quiet opposite effect: it **brings old things and small kindnesses back to the surface** — between houses, between decades, between people who met only because they happened to live on the same stairwell in the same cold morning of the same human winter.

⑩ Tonight, before sleeping, I will write three lines:

December 6. First snow, 07:05. Twenty minutes of sweeping.
Ms Wang's old broom; long broom of mine; a straight path down the middle.
Her hot sugar-water, and a 1976 Kunming photograph. Mandarin — 1957.
Next snow, I will be downstairs first.

注释： widow 寡妇；tangerine 橘子；mandarin 柑橘；refreeze 重新冻结；courtyard 院子

根据短文内容，选择最佳答案。

1. Who did the writer unexpectedly meet at the foot of the staircase on the Sunday morning after the first heavy snow?

A. Her father.
B. Her classmate.
C. Old Ms Wang from Apartment 102, a seventy-nine-year-old widow in a dark blue coat, who was using a very short, very old bamboo broom to sweep the snow herself; her daughter lives more than a thousand kilometres away in Xi'an.
D. A delivery man.

2. Why did Ms Wang finally let the writer take over the sweeping, in her words?

A. She said students must help.
B. She said, "Alright, Yiran. Only for twenty minutes. After that I will make you a bowl of hot sugar-water" — her way of saying thank you without saying it.
C. She threw away her broom.
D. She said she was too cold.

3. After about twelve minutes, what did Ms Wang do?

A. She took the writer's broom.
B. She came down to finish the work herself.
C. She had gone back up to her apartment; then, after a moment, her window opened and she called softly, "Yiran, the water will be ready in five minutes!"
D. She went to the corner shop.

4. What story did Ms Wang tell in her apartment, and what did she say at the end?

A. A story about her old school.
B. A winter story from when she was thirteen, ill for a week, when a neighbour boy named Huang Ruyi (about ten or eleven) swept the snow in front of her courtyard with a too-short broom; her teacher-mother gave him a small red mandarin, which he peeled in the snow, half for him and half for her. She said, "Today you swept my path. In some way, the world has returned a little piece of that morning to me. Thank you, Yiran."
C. A story about a market.
D. A story about a train.

5. What does the writer realise about snow at the end of the story?

A. Snow is just a nuisance to sweep away.
B. Snow seems to cover everything, but it actually has a quiet opposite effect — it brings old things and small kindnesses back to the surface — between houses, between decades, and between people who met only because they happened to live on the same stairwell in the same cold morning of the same human winter.
C. Snow is dangerous and everyone should stay inside.
D. Snow is only useful for children's games.

答案与解析

1.
【答案】C
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第①②段相遇
【解析】"102 / 79 / 旧竹扫帚 / 女儿在西安"直引。A、B、D 均错。故选 C。

2.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第③段对话
【解析】"二十分钟 / 糖水"直引。A、C、D 均错。故选 B。

3.
【答案】C
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第⑤段
【解析】"五分钟后水好"直引。A、B、D 均错。故选 C。

4.
【答案】B
【题型】细节理解题
【定位】第⑦段往事
【解析】"黄如意 / 红柑橘 / 一片雪地"直引。A、C、D 均错。故选 B。

5.
【答案】B
【题型】主旨大意题
【定位】第⑨段升华
【解析】"旧事 + 小善 + 楼梯间"主旨。A、C、D 均偏离。故选 B。